FINE LIVING
HOTEL





Both the tasteful interiors (Top) and the delicious cuisine (Above) at THE Lotus Palace Chettinad evoke a strong sense of place

around the main one, followed by courtyards for dining, cooking and so on. The mansion has strong bones, as evidenced from the intricate Burmese teak wood-carved entry doors, and the impressive wooden and stone-carved pillars.

Architect Kaushik Mukherjee has done a sensitive restoration job, preserving the mansion's character, while deftly adding modern conveniences. I was settled into the Rani Suite, adorned with charming textiles and the region's famed Athangudi tiles. Saibal Das's dramatic photographs, mostly captured on film, are sprinkled across the property. They depict the palace prior to its restoration and village scenes. The most arresting feature is the Sahasradala Padma (1,000-petal lotus) pattern on the main courtyard floor, a homage to Chettinad's traditional *kolam* patterns.

The signature restaurant, 86 Pillars, features Raja Ravi Varma-influenced stained-glass panels depicting Ramayana scenes, a nod to THE Lotus Palace's setting as a revered location for Ramayana recitals. The innermost courtyard has been transformed into the Park's signature pool-cum-bar offering—Aqua, the perfect spot to unwind.

Kathiravan Karunanithi, the hotel's manager, plays the prefect host. Next morning, he packed me off on a heritage tour of Chettinad with Kavitha, the region's best tour guide. Kavitha's unbridled enthusiasm for her land was infectious. We visited breathtaking palaces, lively markets and a tile factory, but the Vintage Car & Camera Museum was the high point of a morning well spent. I returned to find an Arasavirundhu (Emperor's Feast) waiting for me. This is the ultimate Chettinad meal experience, comprising 15 classic dishes, including the region's fiery non-veg fare.

THE Lotus Palace offers a plethora of experiences besides, from a sunset visit to Thirumayam Fort to fortune telling by a parrotand a kolam-making workshop. There's a spa too.

The most memorable for me was the high tea at The Red Room, an experience reserved for in-house guests. The red lacquer-themed room with Burmese accents evokes the Chettiars' deep connection with Burma. Here, I lounged like the lord of the manor, sipping my *sukku malli* coffee with an array of snacks.

Hotelier Priya Paul, whose measured approach and tasteful vision have been the guiding light of her boutique hotel chain, has a winner in THE Lotus Palace Chettinad. Do take a step back in time and visit this charming jewel in Chettinad's crown.

THE INFORMATION

Accommodation 15 rooms and suites

Tariff ₹18,000 plus taxes

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